

# Checklist

## Engineering Executive: Engineering Onboarding

### Define Clear Goals

- ☐ Increase % of engineers productive within the first 3 months
- ☐ Build foundation for long-term impact (1-3+ years)
- ☐ Define what “productive” means at your company
- ☐ Decide success metrics (time to first PR, first deploy, survey results, etc.)

### Assign Clear Ownership (Critical)

#### Executive Sponsor

- ☐ Appoint executive sponsor (Head of Eng / CTO)
- ☐ Select program orchestrator
- ☐ Define success metrics & monitoring cadence
- ☐ Review onboarding data monthly
- ☐ Meet with outlier new hires (excellent or struggling experiences)
- ☐ Publicly reinforce onboarding’s importance

#### Program Orchestrator

- ☐ Own and evolve onboarding curriculum
- ☐ Coordinate onboarding sessions
- ☐ Create templates for managers
- ☐ Run post-onboarding surveys
- ☐ Track metrics and trends over time
- ☐ Continuously iterate program

- ☐ Ensure the program is sustainable long-term
- ☐ Allocate ≥20 hours/month (minimum expectation)

## **Team Manager**

- ☐ Create a personalized onboarding plan (using template)
- ☐ Schedule weekly 1:1s (first few months)
- ☐ Assign an onboarding buddy
- ☐ Define first 1-3 starter projects
- ☐ Ensure the new hire is added to:
  - ☐ Team meetings
  - ☐ Slack/chat channels
  - ☐ Email groups
  - ☐ Documentation systems

## **Onboarding Buddy**

- ☐ Daily check-ins for first few weeks (15-30 mins)
- ☐ Help set up the dev environment
- ☐ Answer workflow and team-specific questions
- ☐ Bring the new hire to meetings / social touchpoints
- ☐ Help navigate the first project
- ☐ After 1-2 weeks, reassess meeting frequency
- ☐ Keep the manager informed of early friction

## **Design the Curriculum**

### **Core Segments (Start Here)**

- ☐ Engineering values & strategy
- ☐ Technical architecture overview
- ☐ Development environment setup

### **Strengthen Over Time**

- ☐ Survey new hires 1 month after onboarding
- ☐ Survey managers/tech leads on common gaps

- ☐ Remove low-value theoretical content
- ☐ Emphasize practical, real-world context

## **Consider Project-Based Component**

- ☐ Decide: centralized onboarding project vs team-selected starter projects
- ☐ Ensure the project provides:
  - ☐ Real business value
  - ☐ Safe learning surface
  - ☐ Clear ownership
- ☐ Assign tech lead support if centralized

## **Build Peer Cohort Effect**

- ☐ Group new hires when possible
- ☐ Create opportunities for cohort bonding
- ☐ Encourage cross-team networking

## **Decide Who Attends**

- ☐ Require all engineers (all levels)
- ☐ Require all engineering managers
- ☐ Do not allow senior hires to skip
- ☐ Allow other functions (e.g., Product) by request, not default

## **Avoid Common Failure Modes**

- ☐ Keep the program simple enough to sustain long-term
- ☐ Avoid over-engineering or excessive complexity
- ☐ Ensure internal engagement is manageable
- ☐ Plan for orchestrator transition continuity
- ☐ Regularly review and refresh content

Reminder: The worst onboarding programs come from trying too hard, not from starting simple.

## **Coordinate with Company-Wide Onboarding**

- ☐ Reuse company onboarding content where appropriate
- ☐ Avoid duplicating existing materials
- ☐ Keep Engineering onboarding owned within Engineering (when possible)
- ☐ Ensure feedback loops stay within Engineering

## **Decide When to Invest Heavily**

- ☐ Hiring 5-10+ engineers per month → structured program strongly recommended
- ☐ Rapid growth phase → prioritize onboarding
- ☐ Hiring infrequently → consider lightweight/personalized onboarding instead
- ☐ Account for attrition-driven hiring (not just growth)

## **Measure & Improve**

- ☐ Track time-to-productivity metrics
- ☐ Track onboarding satisfaction scores
- ☐ Monitor first-quarter performance trends
- ☐ Identify recurring friction areas
- ☐ Review and iterate quarterly

## **Quick Start Version (If You Need Something This Month)**

If starting from scratch:

- ☐ Assign orchestrator
- ☐ Create 3 core sessions (values, architecture, dev setup)
- ☐ Require attendance for all engineers
- ☐ Assign buddies

- ☐ Run a 1-month feedback survey
- ☐ Improve next cycle